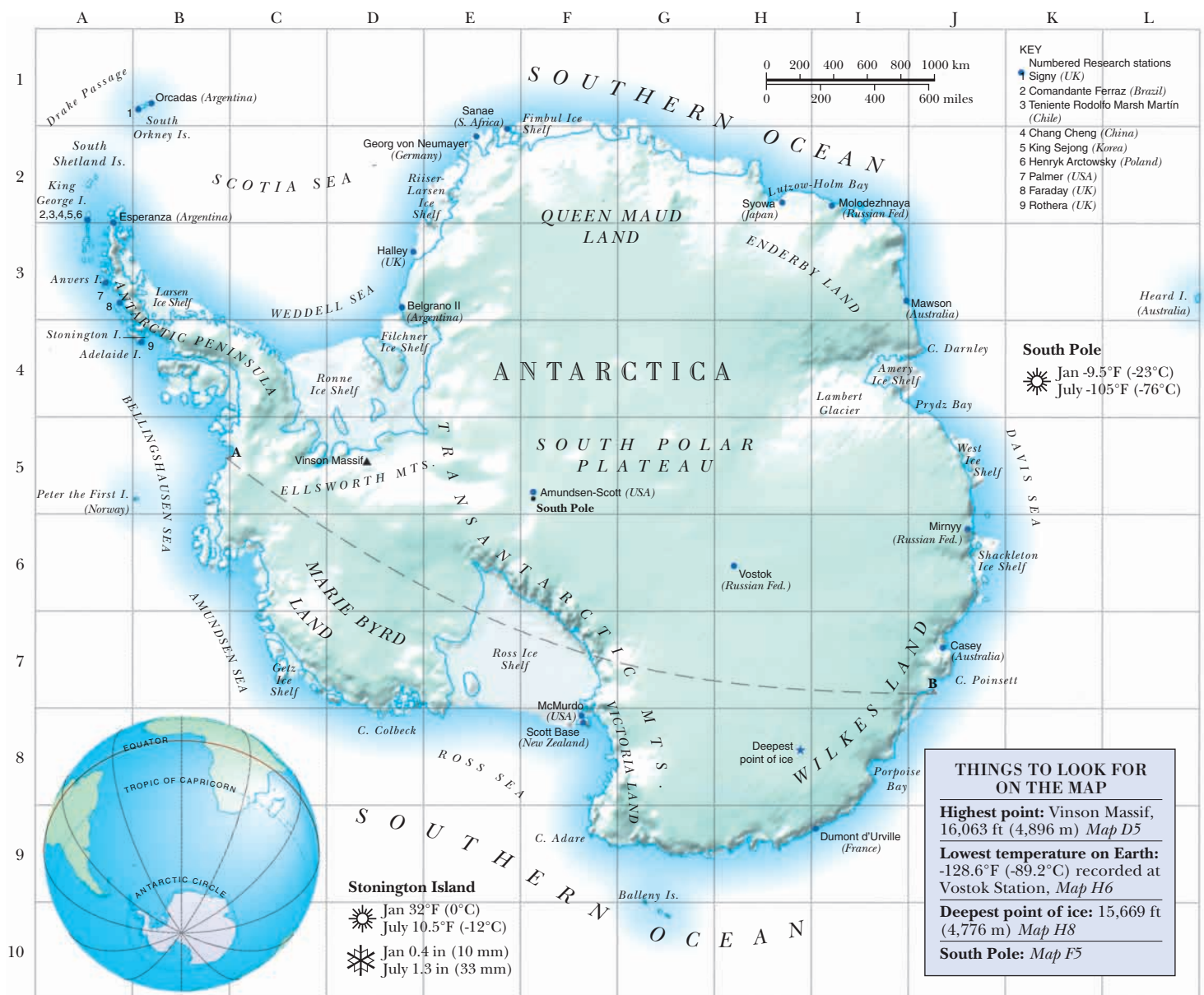


THE ANTARCTIC



CROSS-SECTION THROUGH THE ANTARCTIC
 Antarctica is buried beneath an enormous ice cap that covers 99.6 percent of the land area. It has formed from the buildup of snow compacted over 100,000 years. The ice cap contains most of the freshwater on Earth, and 90 percent of all the ice. If the ice were to melt, the oceans would rise by up to 210 ft (64 m). The ice weighs so much that it pushes much of Antarctica below sea level.

This cross-section follows the line A-B on the map above.

Sea level
A

Ross Ice Shelf

Transantarctic Mountains

Deepest point of ice
B

ANTARCTIC WILDLIFE

Antarctica's severe climate and isolated position have greatly reduced the variety of its wildlife. The largest animal that lives on land all year round is a tiny insect. During the brief summer, however, seals, penguins, and many birds visit the continent to take advantage of the safe breeding sites and plentiful food supply to raise their young. At sea, a dozen species of whale feed off the many seals, fish, and krill that live in the icy waters.

KRILL

Krill are shrimplike crustaceans up to 2 in (5 cm) in length. They feed on plankton and other crustaceans and occur in such large numbers that they sometimes turn the oceans around Antarctica pink.



EMPEROR PENGUINS

The majestic emperor penguin stands up to 4 ft (1.15 m) tall and can weigh 66 lb (30 kg). After spending most of the year at sea, the emperors come ashore in April to breed. The male alone then incubates the single egg during the icy winter, holding it on his feet to keep it warm. The female returns in July to feed the newborn chick.